This extra-special version of the old standard uses fresh, sun-dried, and roasted tomatoes, and takes the humble tomato to new heights.

cream of tomato soup

SERVES 4–6 **PREP** 30 MINS **COOK** 40 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS
BEFORE CREAM IS ADDED

3½ tbsp butter
1 tbsp olive oil
2 onions, finely chopped
2 celery ribs, finely chopped
2 carrots, finely diced
2 garlic cloves, minced
12 plum tomatoes, about 2¼lb (1kg), quartered, roasted, and coarsely chopped
8 plum tomatoes, about 1¼–1½lb (600–720g), peeled and finely chopped
6 sun-dried tomatoes, finely chopped
1 quart (1 liter) hot vegetable stock
2–3 tbsp heavy cream
salt and freshly ground black pepper

1 Heat the butter and olive oil in a heavy saucepan over medium heat. Add the onions and sauté for 8–10 minutes, stirring frequently, until very soft but not colored. Next, add the celery and carrots, and continue cooking gently without burning for another 10 minutes, stirring from time to time. Add the garlic and sauté for another 2 minutes, stirring.

2 Mix together the roasted plum tomatoes, fresh tomatoes, and sun-dried tomatoes. Add them into the pan with any juices, and cook, stirring, for 5 minutes to allow the flavors to combine; if the sauce looks too thick or starts sticking to the bottom of the pan, add a little of the hot vegetable stock. Pour in the remaining vegetable stock and simmer the soup for 15–20 minutes.

3 Blend the soup to a smooth purée using a food processor or hand-held blender. Pass through a sieve or mouli into a clean pan, unless you prefer to make a peasant-style soup. Add the heavy cream a teaspoon at a time until you are happy with the taste and texture. Season with salt and pepper, reheat very gently if needed, and serve.